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It's time to turn off the Flock Safety cameras

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Flock camera on Meadowbridge Road in Highland Park. Photos by Scott Elmquist

If you drive through Richmond today, you are likely being tracked. Your vehicle's fingerprint — its plate, make, model and even your unique bumper stickers and roof rack — is being captured, digitized and stored.

This is the reality of the automated license plate reader (ALPR) network that is dominated by Flock Safety, a private corporation that was valued at **\$7.5 billion** as of March 2025. These

“Flock cameras,” as they are often called, collect data that flows directly into Richmond’s real-time crime center known as **the Capital City Intelligence Center** and Flock’s database. Law enforcement says the network is especially helpful for solving certain crimes, including auto theft, burglaries and kidnappings

Despite **public outcry** regarding the proliferation of ALPR cameras and the civil liberty risks they pose, the Richmond City Council recently decided to continue funding this technology, which disproportionately targets marginalized communities while operating with a startling lack of transparency.



Flock camera on Meadowbridge Rd in Highland Park.

Documented abuses and vulnerabilities

The dangers of this technology are not hypothetical. Across the U.S., ALPR data has been used by law enforcement officers to stalk ex-partners. Privacy advocate Benn Jordan has aptly described these databases as “**Netflix for stalkers**.” Locally, the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives (ATF) **improperly accessed** collected images from Flock cameras in Richmond for an immigration investigation in March, and a Richmod police officer recently **shared Flock data** with a federal agent.

Furthermore, the technology is fallible. In Aurora, Colorado, a family with young children was **held at gunpoint** after officers incorrectly identified their car as a stolen vehicle. **In one instance**, a woman was wrongly accused of a crime because an ALPR camera placed her vehicle in the vicinity.

The technology is also being weaponized politically. In Texas, law enforcement has already used Flock’s surveillance data to investigate a report of **an abortion attempt** in another state after Texas passed its abortion ban. In Richmond, the ALPR database was searched in association with the **No Kings protests** in 2025, demonstrating how easily “public safety” tools can pivot to monitoring political dissent.



Flock camera on Laburnum Avenue near the Richmond Raceway.

The security infrastructure surrounding ALPR data remains riddled with flaws. In June 2024, a division of the U.S. Department of Homeland Security issued an advisory outlining **seven vulnerabilities** in one brand of ALPRs, including missing encryption and insufficiently protected credentials. “White hat” hackers have gained access to massive datasets and found ways to **live-broadcast camera feeds**.

Surveillance inequality

One of the biggest concerns regarding ALPRs is how they both create and reinforce racially biased policing. My colleagues, Drs. Jonny Finn and Andrew Baird, and I recently completed a landmark geospatial analysis titled “**Surveillance Inequality: Race, Poverty, and the Geography of ALPR Deployment**.” Our study of 614 cameras in the Hampton Roads area found that race and class are the primary predictors of where these cameras are placed. (It is worth noting that Hampton Roads officials did not release the locations of these ALPRs willingly; they were forced to do so by a federal judge.) The ALPRs completely encircle Norfolk State University, the region’s only public HBCU, for instance.

In Richmond, geographer Tucker Keener and I conducted a similar analysis using crowdsourced data, because the city refuses to release **ALPR camera locations** (citing the potential for vandalism). The results suggest a pattern similar to that of the one in Hampton Roads. Of the 12 most surveilled census tracts in Richmond, 11 are majority non-white; eight are majority-Black (ranging from 61% to 92% Black); one is majority-Hispanic (60% Hispanic, 30% Black); and one is racially mixed (49% white, 34% Black, 11% Hispanic).

This creates an inevitable and racially skewed feedback loop: police surveil these areas more intensely, generating more data points for low-level infractions, which are then used to justify the initial surveillance. It is a tech-washed version of the same bias-based policing patterns we have fought for decades. This feedback loop ensures that the burdens of surveillance — unnecessary stops, police interactions and data leaks — fall disproportionately on those already marginalized.

Flock camera on Gaskins Road near the I-64 interchange. A sign has been placed underneath the camera, calling attention to the presence of the flock camera.

Profiteering and transparency

Flock Safety's CEO claims the technology can **eliminate crime**, a statement that is criminologically groundless. These cameras do not prevent crime; they react to it, and they do so by capturing the data of innocent Richmonders to build a profitable, national database. We must ask: Why is a private corporation allowed to profit from the movement patterns of law-abiding citizens?

While Richmond officials claim numerous cases have been solved via ALPRs, they refuse to provide the raw data for independent verification. We do not know the false positive rate, nor

do we know the cost-per-image of surveilling innocent residents.

As a researcher, I find this lack of transparency incredibly frustrating. Without real transparency, the public is forced to rely on a narrative crafted by police leadership, city officials and the corporation profiting from the contract.

A sign pointing out the flock camera on Gaskins Road.

The myth of legal guardrails

Proponents of ALPR cameras often cite [House Bill 2724](#), which became law on July 1, 2025, as providing sufficient guardrails. The law restricts data usage to active criminal investigations, limits retention to 21 days and prohibits out-of-state sharing. However, [a recent Virginia State Crime Commission report](#) revealed a systemic lack of compliance: 13% of agencies admitted to giving out-of-state entities continuous access to ALPR data; 6% have granted the federal government continuous access; 35% failed to implement required public awareness measures; and 110 departments didn't even complete the survey.

The police are essentially policing themselves — and they aren't doing a great job. It's also important to remember that the federal government is not constrained by HB2724, and the law cannot prevent other states, private companies or the federal government from accessing Richmonder's data through subpoenas or search warrants, including those issued to Flock Safety's headquarters in Georgia.

The legal criteria for using these cameras are also dangerously broad. Law enforcement can use ALPR photos for any investigation involving reasonable suspicion. This can range from homicide to littering or jaywalking, and certain exemptions allow data to be stored indefinitely. Additionally, individuals can be placed on “hotlists” for anything from serious crimes to unpaid court fees, triggering alerts every time they pass a camera. The law also does not restrict AI from being used to create algorithms to surveil specific groups of people.

Flyers near Highland Park calling for the removal of flock cameras.

The right to be left alone

The Fourth Amendment protects us against unreasonable searches and seizures. While courts have been slow to catch up to the scale and capabilities of modern dragnet surveillance, the moral question remains: Should the government be able to track you when you have done nothing wrong?

Our city leaders should not fund a system that targets Black and brown residents, bypasses state safeguards and enriches a private corporation at the expense of our Fourth Amendment rights. In May, **Mayor Avula announced** the Richmond Police Department would no longer allow federal agencies to access the city’s ALPR data and that the city would prohibit data sharing with any Virginia jurisdiction that has entered into **a 287(g) agreement** with ICE. But **cities like Staunton and Charlottesville** have cancelled their Flock contracts altogether after recognizing the risks.

Richmond should follow their lead. It is time to turn the cameras off for good. It is never too late to do the right thing.

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